

bouncers. Teams strategically used the two-bouncer-per-over rule, introduced in this IPL, to keep him quiet at times, but with no such provision at the World Cup, the left-hander is likely to get some breathing space.

While the ongoing IPL may have turned out to be a run-fest, the perception surrounding the upcoming T20 World Cup is that conditions in the USA and especially the Caribbean might be a little less batter-friendly.

As a result, the selectors have packed the squad with as many as four spin-bowling options. All of India's group matches have got either a 9.30 am or 10.30 am start, which rules out the possibility of dew troubling the tweekers while gripping the ball and imparting spin while delivering.

And then there's the thing nobody is working up a sweat about yet, but frankly, it's an area that is key to redressing the bat-ball balance during the World Cup: India's pace attack. With the exception of redoubtable Jasprit Bumrah, the other two members — Mohammed Siraj and Arshdeep Singh — have had an up-and-down IPL season.

While Siraj has conceded close to 10 runs an over in the IPL PowerPlay so far, taking five wickets while averaging close to 50, Arshdeep has been slightly better, taking seven wickets in the PowerPlay at an economy rate of close to nine and an average of 34. Siraj's struggles have spilled over into the death overs, where he currently has three wickets at an eco rate of 9.15. Arshdeep has more wickets between 17 and 20 — nine but at 12.1 runs per over.

The bowling numbers, of course, have been askew this year, thanks in part to the Impact Player rule, which was introduced in IPL 2023 and allows teams to bring in a 12th player at any point in a match to replace a player from the XI after the toss. The absence of it in the ICC tournaments should help allrounders wrest some of the advantage back from specialists.

India has four all-rounders in Hardik, Dube, Axar Patel and



Top class Jasprit Bumrah has taken 20 wickets this IPL, with a solid economy rate of 6.48. K. R. DEEPAK

Ravindra Jadeja, but given the makeup of the squad, it is highly likely only two will feature in the XI.

India may not have the sense of T20 ideological purity of England or the peak West Indies yet, although it may have a wider array of options to break down opponents. And much

as the world loves the heady euphoria generated by the barnstorming nature in which the modern T20 game is played, the overarching feeling is that India will once again live by the adage that defence is as important a part of cricket as attack.



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